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Interactions Between Sociology as A Discipline and Maritime Industries and Related Pursuits with Special Reference to The South China Sea Coast

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ABSTRACT

Sociology is the systematic study of social behaviour and human groups. It focuses primarily on the influence of social relationships upon people's attitudes and behaviour and on how societies are established and change. As a field of study, sociology has a very broad scope. For the purposes of this commentary, there will be a narrowing to embody the key interactions between people who live, work and recreate in the relatively narrow belt where the land meets the sea. Of course, the full extent of the interactions may be felt far away because rivers and canals link the hinterland with the coastal zone. This paper makes several contributions to the growing body of literature in the application of the tools used by sociologists to assess and evaluate the multi-faceted nature of the trends emerging from the growth and importance of maritime industries and related pursuits along the South China seacoast. Beginning with a very brief history ideas about the land/sea interactions and some analysis of examples of environmental determinism in practice.

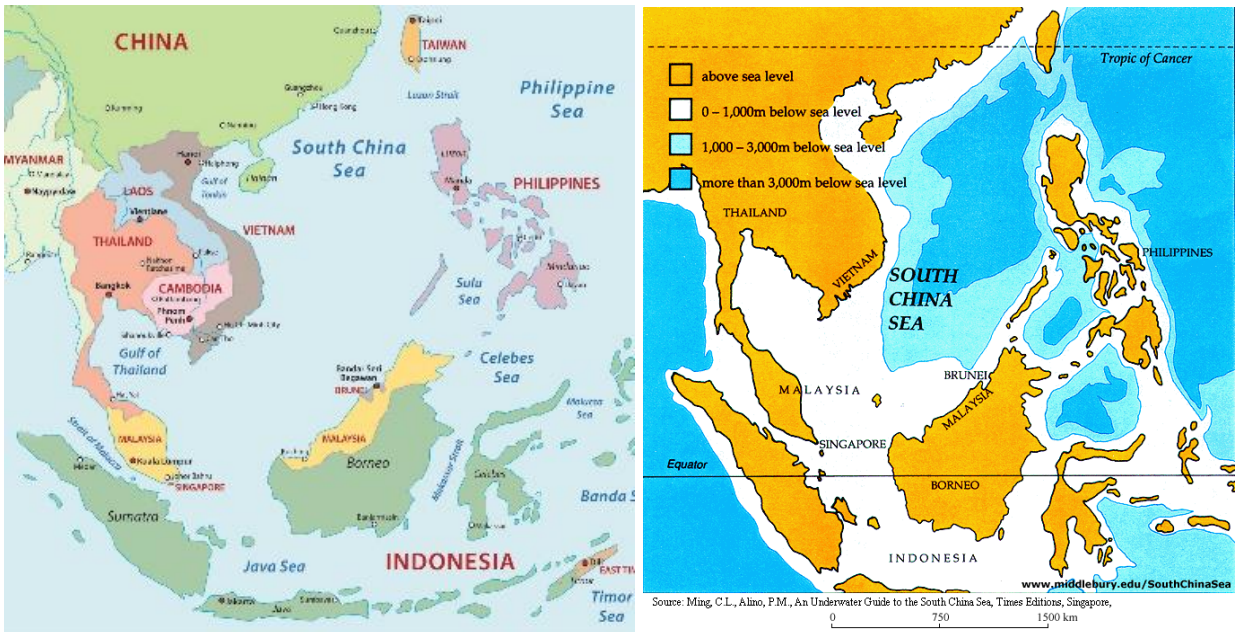
Keywords: history of ideas, coastal zone, hinterland, environmental determinism, hazards, shipping, trade, marine aquaculture, industry, culture, urbanization

CONTEXT AND SETTING

The South China sea (Fig. 1Left, 1 Right) is a large and complex alternation of islands, rocky outcrops, and mainland coastlines (shelf).

The shelf of the South China sea in the Gulf of Tonkin (Bei Bu Gulf) is the focus of this paper. Water depth is in the range of 0-1000 m. The different water depths affect the impact of typhoons and tsunamis and storm surges. But they create conditions favourable to various fish, crustaceans and bivalves. These aquatic resources are the foundation of livelihoods for many. Residents along the shelf are acting to mitigate the stormy weather and remedial action (like sea walls) to minimise damage. Early warning systems are in place and radar and satellite imagery are on 24/7 alert (Feng, Zhu, Wu & Squires, 2003). Preparedness is the key to adapting to these marine incursions. Feng et al., 2023 review the impact of disaster and consideration is given to aspects of the process of engaging with local communities in areas at risk of disasters

and in those sites that are affected with severe consequences on peoples' income, wealth, health, and social state. Vulnerability is an important factor and its nature and implications are examined through the lens of a sociologist.



THEMES TO BE EXPLORED

A number of themes recur throughout the South China Sea foreshore and adjacent hinterland. These are listed in the accompanying Theme chart (Fig.2). Some will be dealt with in more detail here while the bibliography will allow the interested reader to explore the details.

Society and Maritime Enterprises and Pursuits
Social ecological systems Ecosystem services Culture and heritage Ethnicity and Gender
Demographics Population growth, Migration and displacement Land use conflicts
Urbanisation social structure waste disposal
Benefit sharing
Disaster management Early warning Mitigation, preparedness Reconstruction
Transport and distribution Integrated Ship, Rail, Road and Canal

Figure 2: A Theme chart of key interactions between sociological and maritime phenomena

In many parts of China, rapid economic growth, socioeconomic inequality, and environmental degradation (air, water, soil) are undermining social stability and sustainable urbanization. Rural-urban migration is the main factor contributing to urban population growth. Economic opportunity in urban areas is the main 'pull factor' but government policies provide a 'push factor' (Feng & Squires 2018). Cropland abandonment because of rural depopulation or policy interventions has become a key issue in hinterland mountainous areas. One such region is the Guangxi Karst Mountainous Area (GKMA), a zone where more than 59% of total land area is hilly and arable land of a commercially viable size is almost non-existent. The rugged terrain and land fragmentation dominate (Feng and Squires 2022).

DEVELOPMENT ALONG THE SOUTH CHINA SEA

It is a scene of rapid expansion of marine enterprises related to divergent activities like port facilities, defence installations, marine aquaculture, artisanal fishing and seaside tourism based on a few sandy beaches. On shore there are boat building businesses, marine engineering facilities, oil storage and refinery.

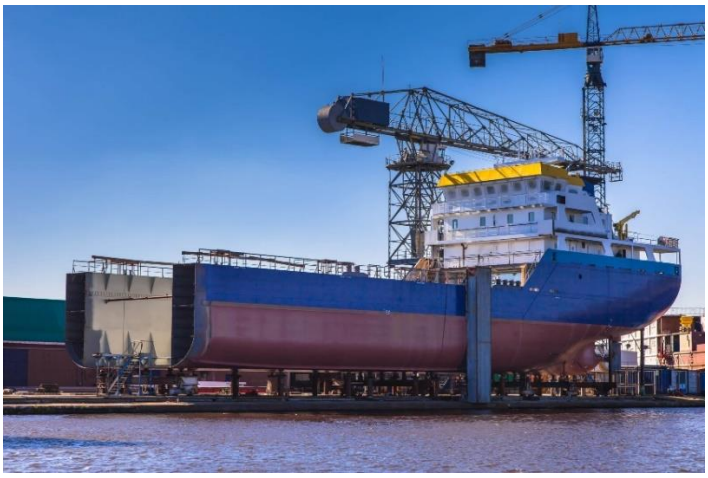


Fig. 4: Boat building is just one of the major new maritime industries

A key feature is the integration of port, road, rail and canal transport. High speed (bullet trains) running on dedicated freight corridors provide rapid freight movement across China.

Fig.5: High speed freight trains run through dedicated freight corridors

For example, the high sped train cuts 17 hours off the 2000 km journey from the port of Qinzhou (on the Bei Bu Gulf) to Lanzhou a major inland city on the Yellow river and a junction for goods trains travelling to Europe along the New Silk road. Similarly, high speed freight trains go south to Vientiane in Cambodia with local connections to neighbouring countries. Cross border *e*-commerce between China and Vietnam is gathering pace.

THE NEW MARITIME SILK ROAD

Maritime regions have played a major role in the history of China and indeed in many countries around the world. Maritime exploration and trade, often led by China (Cartwright, 2019) have played a pivotal role in shaping the course of human history, fostering cultural exchange, economic growth, and the spread of new ideas. These endeavours have connected continents, enabled the rise and fall of empires, and transformed isolated societies into interconnected global communities. Such is the newly revived Maritime Silk Road that is part of China's ambitious Belt and Road initiative (Fig. 6). The sociological impact of these major engineering feats is enormous. There is much opportunity for multidisciplinary teams to study the 'ripples' as these mega projects unfold.

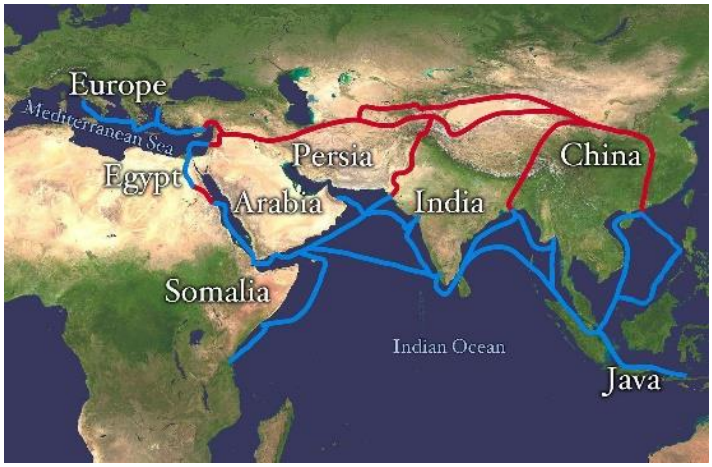


Fig. 6: Route map of the ambitious Belt and Road initiative

China looks to ASEAN countries for closer ties and freer trade and ports like Qinzhou and Fangchenggang the Bei Bu Gulf are the closest to ports in Thailand, Malaysia, Philippines. Fangchenggang is the most convenient gateway for the hinterland of China to enter ASEAN as it shares land, sea and rivers with the countries of ASEAN. angcheng Port, the largest port in western China, deals with business with more than 190 countries and regions around the world and with the integrated road, rail and water transport networks there is tremendous opportunity to foster trade, especially as there are now free trade zones in China's southwest.

LAND GRAB: CONTROL OVER LANDS AND WATERS

From the earliest days of hunting grounds and fisheries, there have been attempts by groups to gain control over lands and waters. A new wave of land grabbing has emerged in China as land was acquired and converted to new uses such as roads, bridges, canals, railways, factories, large scale greenhouses for food production and so on (Feng & Squires 2021).

Not only has the land been assigned to a new land use but the lives of people whose land was grabbed was forever altered. Some displaced persons were employed later in construction jobs but for others it ended a lifestyle and means of livelihood. An example is the relatively recent transfer of artisanal fishers, who had always lived on their boats, to government-provided housing on the mainland.

The interactions occur between the human population who occupy land on the margins and the growth, expansion and magnitude of maritime pursuits, shipping, ship building, cargo handling, especially containers. The Bei Bu Gulf has become a site for creation of major port facilities. Large container vessels require deeper channels and dredging occurs regularly. The turbidity of the water has suffered and the nearby marine aquaculture facility that farms crustaceans and ~~The turbidity of the water has suffered and the nearby marine aquaculture that farms~~ various shell fish (all of which are filter feeders) has been adversely affected. Bilge water and fuel leaks have contributed to declining water quality in Bei Bu Gulf. Mangrove woodlands along the foreshore have been receding as water turbidity and surface roughness has changed as large ships manoeuvre to their respective berths. Mangroves are important in the life cycle of fish and loss of trees makes hatchlings and small fry more susceptible to predators.

Fig. 7: Large container ships need deeper water and regular dredging creates turbidity

A LAND TRANSFORMED

Guangxi has a subtropical climate and in its undisturbed state, soils and climate com- bine to favour a mix of trees, shrubs and understorey plants. But since the late 1970s *Eucalyptus* plantations have transformed the landscape, interfering with local people's ability to harvest non wood forest products as "native " trees and shrubs are replaced by monocultures of eucalypts. Guangxi is a major area of eucalyptus plantations. The eucalyptus industry has become the one of the dominant and specialized industries of the province, and serves as a source of livelihood for many rural people living in Guangxi. The promotion of the industrial development of eucalyptus plantations in Guangxi in the 20th century not only plays an important role in the overall economic and social development of GZAR, but also has great significance in the promotion of the sustainable development of the national timber industry and it supports the entire scale of economic and social development of the hinterland adjoining the coastal shelf.

SUMMING UP AND CONCLUSIONS

As we illustrate in this document, there are numerous points where interactions, both positive and negative, can (and do) occur. In a rapidly changing world it is easy to lose site of the importance of input by the sociologists. Avoidance of conflict, maintenance of stability and harmony is more likely to be achieved if there is a more equitable sharing of the benefits that arise from "development".

Future research might tackle issues such as "how should we understand the intersection of society (sens lat.) and maritime industries and related pursuits?

"How can we attribute causal significance in social matters to disaster-related events and aftermaths? To what extent does 'society' exacerbate problems that arise when development benefits the many and has an adverse effect on the few?

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